AS ONE REBEL PUT IT, "UDDHAVJI CHOSE TO RISK LOSING HIS OFFICIAL RESIDENCE AND 40 MLAs BUT NOT PAWAR. IT WAS DETRIMENTAL"

prone to go into his own shell where a vibrant earth connection is required. Bal Thackeray could afford his majestic aloofness: loyalty towards him was writ in blood. But Uddhav—even if physically infirm and in fact more so because of it—needed his own renewal of that link between leader and faithful. Instead, he trusted only a few and looked at others with suspicion. These two personality traits proved his Achilles' heel.

Signs of what was to come were clearly visible just days before Shinde, a staunch Sainik from his salad days in politics, raised the flag of insurrection. The scene was the party's 56th foundation day on June 19 at Mumbai's Hotel Westin. All of the Sena's 55 legislators had been assembled there, partly to 'keep them united' ahead of the legislative council election the next day. Clad in a brown full-sleeved kurta, primly buttoned up as always, Uddhav occupied the central chair on the dais. Ranged on his right, in this order, was son and environment minister Aaditya, the Sena's Marathwada tutelar lord Diwakar Raote, and only then a sombre-looking Shinde—Thane strongman and group leader in the assembly. Uddhav spoke in pleasant tones about the party's history. And then said: "I am sure about our victory tomorrow...we have no *gaddar* (traitor)." Everyone clapped in appreciation. Except Shinde. He only took off his glasses and started wiping them, as if to rub in the fact of his nonchalance towards the message.

There was a reason for Shinde's mood. A day before, he had reportedly had a heated argument with Aaditya and party spokesperson Sanjay Raut on the quota of votes to be allocated to two Sena candidates—Amsha Padvi and Sachin Ahir—in the council election. Shinde wanted each of them to get 31 votes, against the minimum 26 required, as the party had 62 votes with it (with 55 MLAs and seven associate members). Aaditya



THE UDDHAV REIGN

In his two-and-a-half-year tenure as CM, Uddhav Thackeray did well in two areas—environment conservation and tourism. On the economic and infrastructure fronts, he had a dismal run

HITS

- Expansion of three wildlife sanctuaries and introducing new protected areas
- Radical changes in tourism policy: introduction of agro-tourism, adventure tourism and restoration of forts
- Containing the Covid scare in Mumbai, one of India's most vulnerable hotspots
- Financial and medical help to victims of road accidents

MISSES

- All major infrastructure projects like Mumbai Metro, Samruddhi Expressway and Mumbai-Ahmedabad high-speed train are running behind schedule
- No action plan on containing inflation
- Shoddy state of law and order
- No new investments or projects